

**Good morning Daddy,**

This message isn't fully polished, but I felt the need to soften my words and clarify where they come from.

**Before you read further, I want to say this:** What follows is long and covers a lot of ground—some of it difficult. It touches on my earlier rude toilet comment, on money, on being gay, and on disappointments I've carried quietly for years. I'm not sending this to hurt you. I'm sending it because I may not have many opportunities to say these things piece by piece, and I'd rather you understand where I stand than have you guess or assume the worst.

I trust you to do what you've always done well: set emotions aside, take your time, and think through things calmly. That's something positive I learned from you and still hold onto. So please read this in that spirit—not as an attack, but as your son trying to be honest with his father.

I also know human beings tend to remember the bad more than the good, especially when emotions are involved. So please keep in mind: for every difficult or hurtful thing in this message, I do know there are countless good things you've done and continue to do. I carry those with me too.

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**I worry about you.**

Just as parents worry about their children, children worry about their parents. I think about where your headspace is—not just whether you'll have financial security in retirement, but what you're still reaching for. Whether you're preparing to retire and simply wind down, or whether you remember that as a father five times over and now a grandfather four times over, with more to come by God's grace, more is expected of you than simply the basics.

You had immense privilege:

- Early childhood education by sitting in your father's classes—a strong indicator of future educational attainment
- Scholarships from Nigerian communities and the government
- Attending UI when it was on par with today's top-ranking universities
- Becoming one of the most highly educated people in the country, whose voice already commands respect

I wonder if you ever saw these as privileges, or just as things that happened. I wonder what ambitions you held beyond becoming a professor and chairing a department. I wonder what happened along the way.

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**About my earlier comment regarding the toilet—**

I apologize again. Despite the observation being rooted in something real for me, it was extremely rude to share it that way.

Lee Kuan Yew, in **From Third World to First**, wrote about using the state of public toilets as a metric for judging how developed a place is. When he landed somewhere, he'd look at the toilets and know what to expect of the people. I've found this holds true for families too. But that's an internal metric—not something I should have thrown at you the way I did.

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### **About money and control—**

When you give money out of care a.k.a love, please give freely and be happy without any expectation of a return, or don't give at all - this is basic Catholic theology.

From my own small life experience I very quickly learned that using money as a means of control, or giving while attaching strings of any sort or expectations on the recipient towards you to repay or show subservience in some way, or even to show gratitude, outside the scope of a predefined repayment plan, or where the money wasn't explicitly asked for, leads to resentment. You and mummy seem to find this extremely hard and I suspect it's simply because you didn't have the privilege you gave your children of growing up in comfort without having to ever worry about the basics. Fyi, you actually have a reputation among your colleagues, Dr Jibril for instance, of being a tight pocketed man.

I want to be clear: I am genuinely grateful for this trip and grateful that you wanted to help make it possible. Thank you. But my arrangement was with Ogoma. She assured me she wasn't in financial distress using her credit card to fund my trip. So as far as I understood it, Ogoma funded my trip, not you, or your wife.

And you have every reason to be happy because this trip has helped me grow even more in such a short time and tackle mental concerns I've been grappling with which were encouraging my use of illicit drugs to cope with.

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### **About why I hold certain views—and how long I've held them:**

Growing up, you were my hero. The paragon of integrity and conscientious. I assumed you had good reasons for keeping the family in Nigeria, for the choices you made, for not teaching us our mother tongue. I assumed there was a larger plan I couldn't yet see.

That changed during one of my first exam seasons in the UK, when you and Mummy came over in what I can only describe as full blown mania, with mummy talking about stripping naked or something if we (Chidi and I) didn't make time to see you instead of studying for exams which were causing us enough distress already, so of course we did. It struck me then that neither of you fully understood what you were doing as parents, and that you didn't have good mentors guiding you either. That observation made me take pity on both of you tbh and commit to causing you as little trouble while in the UK as I could.

Because it became obvious you hadn't done the geopolitical and policy research that more prepared parents do when deciding where to send their children.

You hadn't understood what well-positioned families actually send their children to university for—not just to get degrees, but to make friends with children from similarly minded families, to learn to be agents who shape the world rather than react to it. The degrees themselves are basic; the real value is in relationships with people who will go on to influence how things work. Things such as whether their children can make a phone call to the local government chairman's son to ask him to tell his father to fix the road leading to their house.

You showed up at a critical time in the academic calendar without understanding the nature of competition in modern advanced countries. How cutthroat it is. The pressure and extremes people go through just to get basic white-collar jobs.

And how could you have known? Since your first job offer at UCH, you never challenged yourself to go higher. Perhaps it became too difficult—being a father and husband to a wife who was growing mentally ill while pursuing her own legitimate career ambitions with her limited business education and global exposure, all while raising five children. Perhaps you checked out at some point. I don't know.

I still highly respect Mummy because of her ambition and humility. All of us siblings think she needs help.

I'm not sure what my siblings think about you. But I gave you both a vote of no confidence that day—in your ability to prepare me for the modern world, especially as a gay man—and I decided I was on my own.

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### **About Bristol—**

Thinking back, I might be in a better position to help you now if you and Mummy had trusted my judgment and let me study Computer Science at the University of Bristol.

I had chosen Bristol because:

- It was cheaper than Queen Mary in both fees and rent
- Northern England is known for being more down-to-earth; loneliness and isolation would have been less severe
- It had something like over 95% internship placement rates with top firms like Google, right from first year, and it fell within the catchment area for elite recruitment.

But at the time, I still believed you both knew what you were doing. When you said no—not UCL, not Bristol, Queen Mary because it's closer and we need you to emotionally support your brother—I said okay.

However had you been present in our lives during secondary school, you would have known how absurd this "emotional support" arrangement with Chidi actually was. Chidi tried to be

the cool kid and was friends with bullies who sometimes bullied me in ISI. My very first interaction with him at school, he threw the lunch money you typically gave him to hold onto the floor with a sneer on his face, and I had to pick it up. That set the tone for our entire secondary school relationship.

It was so hurtful that I decided Ugo would never experience a brother like that. But as a young gay boy figuring out his life and probably autistic about the Catholic church and what they taught—watching his parents do the whole "my first son in the Igbo family gets all the privilege" thing—I didn't have the energy to fight it. I had more important things to think about, like how to go from barely passing my entrance exams to mastering school content. That's what informed the friends I made: Tolu Odunola, Roseben Anyanwu, Ibukun Olujumi—the people in class who embodied the type of students you wanted us to be.

I said okay and was grateful you were sponsoring my education and taking me out of Nigeria. But I was confused.

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### **About Chinazo and Ogoma—**

On finances, I think you owe Chinazo and Ogoma an apology. I always found it unfair that the sons got to study abroad first. Had that short-sighted policy not been made, they might have done well enough early enough to ease you of the burden of financing your sons' educations abroad.

They never mention it, but I suspect this is a good reason why Chinazo is disappointed with Mummy—that she gave in to her premodern notions of gender roles and treated the girls like second-class children.

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### **About my sexuality, depression, and suicidality—**

These are things I've firmly decided I am solely responsible for. Any help is appreciated, but as an adult, this is my burden to carry. It would be good for our relationship to not center on it. Honestly, it's not anyone's business.

I read your message about not understanding why gay people are more suicidal. You wrote that if someone is unhappy being gay, they can simply choose not to be gay, the way people choose celibacy to become priests or nuns.

Daddy, it doesn't work that way. Gay people aren't more suicidal because they're unhappy with being gay. They're more suicidal because of how the world treats them—rejection from family, condemnation from religion, discrimination, violence, the constant message that something is fundamentally wrong with us. The pressure comes from outside, not inside.

So as I already shared, if you ever want to understand this better, please read *\*Prayers for Bobby\**. It's the true story of a gay man who killed himself under pressure from ultra-religious

parents. After he died, his mother spent the rest of her life fighting for the rights gay men now have in America. It might help you see what I mean.

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### **About why I came out the way I did—**

I did not come out to you in Nigeria and shut down my social feeds to go completely private and docilely accept your attempts to change my choice because I needed acceptance from you. I did it because it took me about thirteen years to grapple with my situation myself and it was clear you would need time to adjust yourselves. In my eyes at the time, you had been such exceptional parents to me compared to what I saw and still see in other families, that you deserved the grace of having time to grapple and prepare yourselves for when I finally decided to live my life outside your shadow.

Coming out the American way was incompatible, in my opinion, with the Igbo Nigerian family that we are. That way of "love me or I cut you off"—I thought it very stupid and inconsiderate of the pains of raising a child, keeping them alive, and seeing them through school to what I'm sadly coming to realize was the best you could both do.

I shut down and went private because I was afraid. Would being openly gay affect my sisters' marriage prospects? Would Mummy have a heart attack when she found out? Would the family be in danger? These were the questions I carried.

But being gay has been such a blessing to me.

You said I could have been a priest. But I wonder if Mummy remembers when I told her at Fontanna that I wanted to become a priest. She was so busy at her office—you know that one after we'd moved from the first site to the second site, and her office was in the main building near the indoor crèche, across the compound from my class where we once killed a green snake we spotted on the fence. She was oblivious to the distance her children were starting to feel from her as her new baby Fontanna took all her attention and energy. We watched it suck the soul out of her. As this happened a dynamic of camaraderie and emotional support was already forming among the siblings as we all looked to each other for the warmth our parents were losing the capacity to give.

Her son, in primary school, was telling her he wanted to be a priest because he was grappling with how to live in a society and religion that hates gay men. He was looking to the only pillar of strength he had in his life at the time to guide him. And all she asked was: "Are you sure?"

All I could see was the stress on her face from her work. So I said no.

What I meant was: I do not want to stress you any further. You are not smiling. And I think this will make you even more sad.

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## **About my depression—**

I want to be clear about something else: if I am depressed or suicidal, it is not primarily because of being gay. It is because I am extremely hard on myself. I see the privilege I have received, and I know that much more is expected of me.

When I compare myself to my closest friends, I see what people can achieve with far less:

Douglas Kendyson—raised by a single mother, the father figure and head of his family, working relentlessly to put his sisters through school.

Kunle Ologunro—went through university with only a breaking-down phone, from which he started his illustrious writing career. He comes from a massively dysfunctional and poor family by our standards, with a father who still depends on him financially and a mother doing her best selling pure water and drinks in Lagos. He was raised by his grandmother and shuffled between homes.

These are my friends. This is what they've overcome. And when I measure myself against what they've built with what they were given versus what I've built with what I was given, I know I have a lot of work to do. If I ever feel like killing myself, it is because I am nowhere close to what is expected of me given what I have received.

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## **Finally—**

You wrote that the Bible tells us to forgive 70 times 7 times, but each dart leaves a scar on the board. That words once spoken cannot truly be taken back.

I know. I am working on controlling my emotions and preventing outbursts. I will continue to work on that.

But I also want you to understand that some of what I carry isn't an outburst—it's years of quiet observation and disappointment that I've never had the chance to explain.

I'm explaining it now. Not to wound you, but so you know where your son actually stands.

I told you yesterday that if I had married you on your potential the way your wife did, and you became the man you did, I would have left you long ago. That is true. And I am grateful you have raised daughters whom I trust will not put up with that lackadaisical husbands.

But please remember: your children are still your children. We love you. I love you. My only desire has been that you be happy in life. It's just that—well, you're not, at least not from my perspective. And it's frustrating that personally I am too incompetent to help, or perceived as too mentally addled by my parents to do so.

This last part about your perception of me is what became clear by yours and your wife's behavior when I landed at the airport in Lagos.

That the notion I cannot fend for myself, that I do not know how to live in my own home country which I dearly love, where I built my fledgling career a second time over from scratch in Lagos, jumping molue oh, okada oh, queuing for hours at the motor parks under the sun, getting to work in the drenching rain, day after day, despite his clinical depression, cannot safely find my way to my home and is not FULLY aware of the situation on ground wherever I'm going, would even remotely cross your mind, it told me enough. You have no idea who your son is or how he sees himself, and that is on you, not me.

Your son,  
Dozie

P.S

Please have a good day and a safe trip to Lagos. And I pray that you do not hold on to negative emotions of any sort. This letter is not looking to hurt, just to explain.

If it helps, I take a lot of joy and pride in how you impact the lives of your patients, and I still have a lot to learn from you about that spark I see in your eyes when you speak about your work, and often find myself hoping that one day I too will do work which brings such impact and such a spark to my eyes.

And if you're curious, ever since reading about his life in my only year at UI, Lee Kuan Yew has been my hero. One thought which has helped with my addiction is remembering how he quit smoking to be healthy and live long to be a servant leader. I, too, hope to be a servant leader who plays a part in Nigeria's growth.